LIFE RPG — Project Brief

Version: 1.0
Date: October 2025
Purpose: Project specification for AI-assisted development

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1. Personal Context

- BTech graduate, 2025
- Currently learning JavaScript via freeCodeCamp
- Completed HTML + CSS basics
- Currently studying: JavaScript objects
- **Approach:** build while learning — do not wait to "master JS first"
- Role: product owner + architect. AI writes code; human understands and directs.

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2. AI Tool Setup

Tool	Role
Gemini Pro	Main code generation
ChatGPT	Supervisor / architecture reviewer
Claude	Refactoring, docs, alternate explanations
DeepSeek	Deep thinking, strategy, debugging, direction

Working rule: AI writes code, but the human must understand every file line-by-line. No blind copy-paste. If a generated file cannot be explained, stop and break it down.

Note: AI agents cannot access other AI tools or accounts by default. Each tool is used independently.

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3. Rejected Project (for the record)

Idea: An app that searches across all food delivery platforms to find the lowest price for a selected food item.

Why rejected:

- No public APIs exist for this purpose
- Scraping is fragile, against ToS, and legally risky
- Item matching across platforms is a non-trivial NLP problem
- True "lowest price" depends on item + delivery + taxes + coupons + distance + time + surge
- Not solo-feasible as a real product

Verdict: Not viable for a solo learning project. Rejected.

(Also covered in conversation: what an API is — a defined interface that lets one program request data from another, usually returning JSON.)

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4. Project Selection

Seven ideas were brainstormed:

1. Life RPG Dashboard
2. Text Adventure Engine
3. Decision Engine
4. Time Capsule / Resurfacing Journal
5. "Should I Buy This?" Calculator
6. Relationship / People Map

7. Skill Tree Visualizer

Chosen: Life RPG Dashboard.

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5. Life RPG — Core Concept

Purpose

Turn self-improvement into a game. Make invisible progress visible. Replace boring habit trackers with a single character sheet for your life that you want to open every day.

Who it's for

- The creator (BTech grad learning JS, building discipline)
- Anyone stuck in the "I want to improve but nothing sticks" loop
- People who grew up on RPGs and wish real life had the same feedback loop

Core Entities

- **Skills** — real-life areas with their own XP and level (e.g., JavaScript, Fitness, Sleep)
- **Actions** — real activities that award XP to one or more skills
- **Levels** — accumulate XP → level up
- **Tiers** — major milestones that unlock character sprite evolution

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6. Character System

4 Stages of Evolution

Stage	Name	Unlocks at Level	Visual
1	Initiate	1	Base sprite, plain, dim
2	Apprentice	5	Small glow, better posture
3	Adept	15	Aura, color shift, gear
4	Master	30	Full glow, evolved form

Transformation Moment

Each stage change is a cinematic event:

1. Screen flash
2. Old sprite fades out
3. Particle burst
4. New sprite fades in with bloom
5. Banner: “You have evolved.”

Art

- Static sprites for now (no frame-by-frame animation)
- 4 sprites total, one per tier
- Placeholder art in v1 (simple images/colors)
- Real pixel-art sprites in v2
- Idle float via CSS (sprite breathes/floats gently)

Future Animation (deferred)

Real character animation (walking, coding, lifting) possible via:

- Hand-drawn sprite sheets (Aseprite, Piskel)
- Rigged 2D (DragonBones, Live2D)
- Blender 3D → render to 2D sprite sheet

Not in v1. Not in v2. Evaluate later.

7. Visual Direction

Earlier Idea (rejected)

Dark neon cyberpunk HUD. Rejected in favor of something warmer and more personal.

Final Direction: “The Room”

A cozy, lo-fi, personal room that serves as the home screen, dashboard, and mirror of progress.

Genre name: Cozy room / lo-fi study room / isometric room / digital sanctuary.

Why

- Most habit trackers look like spreadsheets — cold and forgettable
- A room is personal, emotional, and intimate
- The room **evolves** as you level up
- Each zone of the room maps to a skill
- Shareable — people will screenshot their room

References

- Stardew Valley interiors
- Animal Crossing rooms
- Lo-fi Girl YouTube stream
- Pokemon Gold/Silver player’s room
- Coffee Talk
- Habbo Hotel (isometric room + UI overlay)

Art Style

Pixel art. (Confirmed.)

Room Base

The creator's own room, based on a photo they will provide. Cozy desk setup + bed.

Color Palette

Warm amber + deep blue. Soft contrast, cozy, evening-lit feel.

Time-of-Day

Yes — lighting syncs with the user's real local time.

- Morning: warm sunlight through window
- Afternoon: bright, neutral
- Evening: amber lamp, soft shadows
- Night: deep blue, lamp-only, screen glow

Character Placement

Center of the room for v1. May shift to "at the desk" after testing.

Room Layout (v1)

- Desk setup on one side
- Bed on the other
- Window
- Plant
- Character in the center, facing viewer

Tier = Room Evolution

Tier	Name	The Room
1	Initiate	Bare room. Simple desk. One monitor. Dim lamp. Cardboard boxes. Unmade bed. Blank wall.
2	Apprentice	Organized. Plant appears. Poster on wall. Better chair. Warmer light. Two books on shelf.
3	Adept	Dual monitors. String lights. More plants. A rug. Framed art. Reading corner.
4	Master	Dream setup. Large window with view. Multiple screens. Full bookshelf. Ambient smart lighting. Awards on shelf.

Functional Zones (v2/v3)

Each zone maps to a skill — click to log an action:

Zone	Skill
Desk	Coding / Study
Bed	Sleep / Rest
Floor / mat	Fitness
Bookshelf	Reading
Window	Reflection / Journal
Plant	Wellness / Habits

In v1, use a simpler action log button instead.

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8. Structure — Locked

Option C: Hybrid.

- Main screen = character dashboard (the room + HUD)
- Side drawer or bottom nav opens Quests / Stats / Log as overlays
- Feels like one screen but has depth

First screen on open: the room, with the character in the center, waiting.

Loading Screen

- App opens → loading screen appears
- Logo morphs through identities: game controller → code brackets → smiley → RPG shield → Life RPG sigil
- Then fades out and the app loads
- **Max duration: 2 seconds**

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9. Animation Plan

v1 (CSS animations only)

- Idle float (sprite breathes/floats)
- Glow pulse
- Level-up sequence (flash → fade → particles → bloom → banner)
- Background: slow-shifting gradient + drifting particles

v2+

- Parallax background (mouse-reactive)
- Background changes per tier
- Time-of-day lighting
- Streak-based glow intensity

Later (deferred)

- Character walk cycles
- Contextual animations (coding pose, lifting, resting)
- Requires sprite sheets or Blender pipeline
- Evaluate after v2 ships

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10. Tech Stack

v1

- HTML
- CSS
- JavaScript (vanilla)
- localStorage for data

Not used in v1

- No Node.js
- No React
- No backend
- No database
- No npm

Hosting

Stage	Where
Development	Local — open index.html in browser
Code storage	GitHub repo
Live hosting	GitHub Pages (free)
Shareable URL	yourname.github.io/life-rpg

11. Data Model (rough)

```
const skills = [
  { id: 1, name: "JavaScript", xp: 340, level: 4, tier: 1 },
  { id: 2, name: "Fitness",    xp: 120, level: 2, tier: 1 }
];

const actions = [
  { id: 1, skillId: 1, label: "Studied objects", xp: 40, date: "2025-10-09" }
];

const character = {
  name: "Me",
  totalXp: 460,
  currentTier: 1,
  streak: 0,
  currentSprite: "stage1.png"
};

const settings = {
  timeOfDaySync: true,
  palette: "amber-blue"
};
```

12. XP & Leveling

Launch Skills (v1)

Five skills to start:

1. JavaScript
2. Fitness
3. Sleep

4. Reading
5. Discipline

XP Sources

- **v1:** XP from logged actions only
- **v2:** "Focus Sessions" — start a timer, character works, XP accrues while timer runs (not passive tab-open)

Level Curve

```
XP to next level = 100 × (current level ^ 1.5)
```

Level	XP to next	Total XP
1 → 2	100	100
5 → 6	~1,118	~3,000
10 → 11	~3,162	~11,000
15 → 16	~5,809	~27,000
30 → 31	~16,432	~110,000

Tier Pacing

- Initiate → day 1
- Apprentice → ~1 week
- Adept → ~1–2 months
- Master → ~6+ months

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13. Roadmap

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v1 (first build)

- One character
- 5 skills (hardcoded initially)
- Log an action → XP adds → level updates
- Static sprite swaps at tier thresholds (placeholders)
- Full-screen pixel-art room background
- Character in center
- Floating HUD (XP bar, skill nodes, action button)
- Loading screen with morphing logo
- Animated background (gradient + particles)
- Time-of-day lighting sync
- localStorage persistence
- Runs in browser

v2

- Real pixel-art sprites (4 stages)
- Real pixel-art room (4 tiers)
- Streaks
- History log with filters
- Focus Sessions (timed XP)
- Parallax background
- Room evolution per tier
- Add/edit/remove skills

v3

- Charts (XP over time, radar, heatmap)
- Achievements
- Daily / weekly quests
- Clickable room zones
- Shareable character card

v4+

- Multiple characters (Work Self, Health Self)
- AI coach suggesting quests from patterns
- Social: compare builds, join guilds

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14. Feasibility Summary

Feature	Possible	Difficulty	Version
Loading screen + morphing logo	Yes	Easy	v1
Room as full-screen background	Yes	Easy	v1
Character in center	Yes	Easy	v1
HUD overlay	Yes	Easy	v1
Idle float + glow (CSS)	Yes	Easy	v1
Animated background (gradient + particles)	Yes	Easy	v1
Level-up sequence	Yes	Medium	v1
localStorage persistence	Yes	Easy	v1
Time-of-day lighting	Yes	Medium	v1/v2
Parallax background	Yes	Medium	v2
Room evolution per tier	Yes	Medium	v2
Real pixel-art sprites	Yes	Medium (art)	v2
Clickable room zones	Yes	Medium	v2/v3
Focus Sessions	Yes	Medium	v2
Shareable character card	Yes	Medium	v3
Character walk / action animation	Yes	Hard	v3+

Feature	Possible	Difficulty	Version
Blender → 2D sprite pipeline	Yes	Hard	Later

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15. Next Steps

1. ✅ Concept locked
2. ✅ Visual direction locked (“The Room”, pixel art, warm amber + deep blue)
3. ✅ Structure locked (Hybrid — dashboard + drawer)
4. ✅ Animation plan locked (CSS now, real animation later)
5. ✅ Tech stack locked (HTML + CSS + vanilla JS + localStorage)
6. ✅ XP + leveling locked
7. **Next:** Take this brief to ChatGPT → generate general structure + prompt for Gemini Pro
8. **Then:** Gemini Pro generates v1 code
9. **Then:** Human supervises, understands every file, iterates
10. **Then:** Push to GitHub, enable GitHub Pages, share live URL

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16. Open Items (for later)

- Final pixel-art room design (based on creator’s photo)
- Final sprite design (4 stages, pixel art)
- Exact XP values per action type
- Sound design (optional): chime on XP, tone on level-up
- Reduced-motion accessibility support
- Mobile responsive layout details
- Streak multiplier rules

End of brief.

Copy this whole thing into Google Docs or StackEdit and export as PDF. Want me to now write the **ChatGPT handoff prompt** for the next step?